

fan following. To remedy this, Google launched Android 3.0, christened 'Honeycomb' specifically for tablets. However, the product was an unfinished one during launch which resulted in a number of software glitches and prevented Google from releasing the source code to Android 3.0. One more reason why Android tablets didn't go down too well with consumers is because of the price. Most of the early tablets like the Motorola Xoom were significantly pricier than the iPad (\$800 for the Xoom versus \$499 for the iPad 2). To make matters worse, users complained of malfunctioning hardware like GPS and Wi-Fi issues. Only after the launch of Android 4.0 which brought a unified experience on tablets as well as smartphones, did the Android tablet market start to gain traction. Manufacturers such as Asus and Samsung launched tablets with competent hardware to support Ice Cream Sandwich which prompted developers to release tablet-optimized versions of their apps.

No mention of Android tablets is complete without a reference to the Amazon Kindle Fire. Though based on an older version of Android (Gingerbread, version 2.3) Amazon gave the Kindle Fire a completely new skin and built an ecosystem around it, comprising the Amazon App Store for downloading Kindle-specific versions of apps and leveraging their massive collection of digital content, including ebooks, music and movies. The most important feature of the Kindle Fire though, the one that was responsible for its astounding success, was its price. Priced very competitively at \$199, it sold for less than half the price of the iPad and promised consumers easy access to a world of digital media. Other providers like Barnes and Noble adopted a similar approach with the Nook.

Android in India

Android phones have gained widespread acceptance in India, as they appeal to both the budget conscious as well as those looking for a high-end device. Consumers have started looking beyond feature phones and the vast internet-using population provides a ready market for Android devices. Indian companies like Micromax and Karbonn have introduced low cost Android tablets powered by Android 4.0 (Ice Cream Sandwich) and have created a niche segment for themselves. Reliance Infocomm has entered into an agreement with Google which gives it exclusive rights to market the Android brand in India, along with a 3G data plan of 1GB of free data for a month. 